

LOVE LETTERS

The thought that constantly occupied my mind after blowing out the last candle on my birthday cake was that I had turned sixteen. However, I couldn't help but wonder how long this age would last. With 365 more days to go, I would soon be turning seventeen. It felt like just yesterday when I stood at my last middle school parent-teacher conference, and now here I was, embarking on a new chapter of my life.

During sleepless nights, I often found myself scrolling through Instagram, seeking solace in the small array of light emitted by my phone. As my fingers pressed against the screen, I would come across stories of people partying with their friends. She would suggest going out with them, but little did she know that these people were once my friends—friends who had eventually found someone else to replace me. When Valentine's day came along, a sense of love and affection filled the air, prompting people to express their feelings through various means. While others were busy posting heartfelt messages with dedications, I found myself tapping my foot to the rhythm of the music, absentmindedly doodling on my page. However, despite my lack of concentration, she managed to listen to all my problems and quickly solved them with pep talks.

As I left school, a habit formed unconsciously within me. I would instinctively dial her number before anyone else, eagerly waiting for her voice to tell me to come back home. Often, I was frustrated with his replies when I texted him with a simple answer being "okay". Nevertheless, the following day brought an unexpected surprise as a package was delivered to my front door. Inside was the watch I had previously mentioned to him, indicating that he had indeed paid attention. They often told me to avoid getting into relationships so I could focus on academics. However, they would share their own experiences of how they met and their eagerness for me to find my own moment of happiness.

While concealing my teenage stress, she possessed an understanding of everything that transpired in my life, whether it be guiding me through difficult situations or preparing my favorite meals. Although I couldn't hug them tightly every day, I refrained from expressing my love verbally. However, if I were to become angry with them and engage in arguments, I can foresee that twenty years down the line, the only person I will harbor resentment towards is myself. It is only then that I will realize that during my teenage years, despite believing that no one truly loved me, the individuals I had written about in my journal when I was frustrated were the ones who cared deeply for me.

As I age, those around me will also experience the passage of time. As my physical strength diminishes, so too will theirs. And just as they anticipated and eagerly awaited, I will eventually have a family of my own. I would sit down with my loved ones, my hair now adorned with streaks of gray, gazing at a photograph capturing a precious moment shared together. In that picture, I will see him and her, their smiles radiating alongside mine in the center. Rocking on my chair, my eyes filled with tears holding one of my teenage journal pages, The only words that will escape my lips "Mom, Dad I love you".